

Counterfactual Forks Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-40 min

Category	History	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	counterfactual-forks

Big idea: Counterfactual thinking can clarify causation when it is disciplined by evidence.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Counterfactual Forks Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Counterfactual Forks Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: School example: What if the viral incident had not happened, but earlier complaints still existed?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Counterfactual Forks Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Historical prompt: What if one reform law had failed, while economic and social pressures remained?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Counterfactual Forks Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Historical prompt: What if one reform law had failed, while economic and social pressures remained?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Counterfactual thinking can clarify causation when it is disciplined by evidence.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Counterfactual Forks Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Counterfactual Forks Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Can historians know what did not happen?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- School example: What if the viral incident had not happened, but earlier complaints still existed?
- Historical prompt: What if one reform law had failed, while economic and social pressures remained?

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Activity Steps

1. Choose one historical event or school-history scenario with several causes.
2. Students identify one plausible turning point.
3. Groups change one condition while keeping other constraints realistic.
4. Students predict what would likely, possibly, and unlikely change.
5. Debrief how counterfactuals can test causal claims.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can historians know what did not happen?
- When do counterfactuals clarify causation and when do they become fantasy?
- How do evidence and plausibility constrain historical imagination?

Knowledge Questions

- Can historians know what did not happen?
- How can counterfactuals clarify causation?
- What constrains historical imagination?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with students build branches from a historical decision point. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...